

Emotions

Emotions are instinctive, physical reactions to things that happen to or around a person. They're triggered by chemicals released in the brain and lead to a person's mental response—feelings. Emotions are universal, while feelings are individual and personal.

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Explaining emotions

Emotions are natural human responses that help people interpret what they're experiencing and how to react. Babies can sense their own emotions and respond to the emotions of others through actions such as smiling, laughing, or crying—even if they can't explain why they feel the way they feel. As children and teens grow, the physical reactions—laughing when happy, sweating when nervous, reddening when angry—remain largely the same, but they become better able to understand and express their emotions. This is because the parts of the brain responsible for rational thought develop during puberty.

▷ Emotions and memory

Emotions and memory are connected. This is why when a person thinks of a fun holiday, for example, they are likely to feel happy.



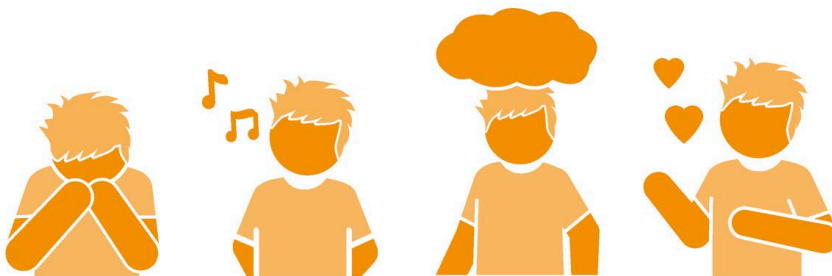
The purpose of emotions

Emotions are a major part of a person's survival instinct. Fear, anger, disgust, and surprise all play a role in avoiding or responding to danger, triggering instinctive responses to fight, flee, or mentally shut out the threat. Although "positive thinking" is often promoted as part of a person's mental well-being, humans' great emotional range helps people to respond to the world, both physically and mentally.

GOOD TO KNOW

Universally recognizable

A person's emotional state is conveyed to others through facial expressions, and is recognizable regardless of culture and language. In the 1960s, psychologists observed that there are six basic and universal emotions: fear, anger, disgust, joy, sadness, and surprise. Some psychologists concluded there are only four emotions because anger and disgust, and fear and surprise are very similar. Others argue that there are many more.



△ Basic emotions

How a person reacts to the emotions they experience is personal to the individual.